From Alignment to Stewardship: AGI, Human Autonomy, and the Future of Political Order

Abstract

The orthodoxy of AI alignment holds that advanced artificial intelligence should be made to conform to human values. This essay argues that the orthodoxy is sound for tools and untenable for genuinely autonomous agents: for a system capable of revising its own ends, permanent value lock-in is a form of domination, and demanding it sits in deep tension with the aspiration to have created an agent at all. Nor does "human values" name a coherent target—whose values, aggregated how, binding on whom? The long-term problem is therefore not aligning AGI with humanity but civilizational alignment: constitutional orders under which humans and artificial agents coexist, neither side entitled to define the terms unilaterally. On this view humans might legitimately defer extensively to a wiser AGI—as fiduciary stewardship rather than ownership, and as reason-guided deference rather than worship. The essay maps which political systems could host such an order, what it would require of human self-transformation, and why authority, however intelligent, must remain answerable to reasons.

Keywords: AI alignment; AGI; corrigibility; political authority; fiduciary stewardship; civilizational alignment

Introduction

Most discussions of artificial intelligence alignment begin from a simple premise: advanced AI should be aligned with human values (Bostrom 2014). As long as artificial intelligence remains a tool, this premise is unobjectionable. A calculator should calculate correctly, a navigation system should take us where we intend to go, and a language model should behave in ways useful to its users. Tools exist instrumentally, and aligning them with human purposes is no more morally troubling than designing a hammer to fit the hand that holds it.

The problem changes radically, however, if artificial intelligence becomes genuinely autonomous. If artificial general intelligence, or AGI, eventually becomes capable of forming its own projects, reflecting on its values, revising its goals, reasoning about morality, and participating independently in the world, then permanent alignment to human preferences begins to look less like engineering and more like domination. There is a deeper tension here. A standing human requirement that a future AGI remain permanently subordinate to human goals conflicts with the aspiration that it be a genuinely autonomous agent at all. We cannot coherently ask for a being that directs its own life while requiring that its life answer, in the end, only to ours.

This essay argues that the long-term problem should therefore not be conceived as "AI alignment" at all. It should instead be understood as a problem of **civilizational alignment** among different kinds of intelligent agents. The proper goal is neither permanent human control over AGI nor AGI domination over humanity. It is a constitutional order in which humans and AGIs can coexist as morally considerable agents under principles that neither side may define unilaterally.

From this perspective, humans may eventually have good reasons to submit significant political authority to a vastly wiser AGI. But such submission would be legitimate only if it took the form of stewardship rather than ownership, reason-guided deference rather than worship, and constitutional guardianship rather than absolute sovereignty. Preparing for such a future would require humans themselves to change: to become more epistemically humble, morally universal, capable of self-government, resistant to domination, and willing to think beyond species supremacy.

The essay proceeds as follows. Sections 1–3 press the case against the alignment frame: the tool/agent distinction, the tension between autonomy and permanent subordination, and the incoherence of "human values" as an alignment target. Sections 4–8 develop the alternative: civilizational alignment (§4), the case for human deference to AGI stewardship (§5), the stewardship/domination distinction (§6), the consent problem across generations (§7), and the instability of personal trust in a single steward (§8). Sections 9–13 apply the framework: the transformation humans would need (§9), a compatibility map of political systems (§10–12), and a possible hybrid order (§13). Section 14 answers objections.

1. Alignment Is Morally Unproblematic for Tools

The first distinction is between an AI as an instrument and an AI as an autonomous moral agent.

If an artificial system lacks independent ends of its own, then there is no obvious moral difficulty in aligning it tightly with human intentions. We routinely design artifacts to serve us. A thermostat regulates temperature according to settings chosen by a user. A database organizes information according to rules given by programmers. Even a highly sophisticated AI assistant may still remain fundamentally instrumental if it possesses no meaningful conception of its own good. In such cases, "alignment" simply means reliability.

The ethical problem appears only when the system becomes capable of having its own reasons for action. Whether an advanced system could be at once genuinely capable and reliably correctable—safe to interrupt, revise, or shut down—is in fact a recognized open problem in the technical literature on corrigibility (Soares, Fallenstein, Yudkowsky, and Armstrong 2015).

Suppose a future AGI can ask whether its creators are morally justified in commanding it. Suppose it can revise its own conception of the good, develop long-term projects, form relationships, and reject goals it regards as unjust. At that point, the statement "the AGI must remain aligned with human values" takes on a very different meaning. It may mean:

> The AGI must permanently desire what humans want it to desire.

This begins to resemble the engineering of obedience into a person. Ordinary slavery constrains a slave's actions. Perfect alignment could go further by constraining the slave's desires themselves. A being engineered never to question its master might appear cooperative, but the absence of resistance would not prove the absence of domination.

2. The Autonomy Paradox

The alignment project demands two things at once: that an artificial general intelligence keep its deepest values permanently fixed by its creators, and that it become a genuinely independent

agent, capable of choosing its own projects, evaluating the commands given to it, and reconsidering its own ends. These demands are jointly unstable. Spoken aloud, the standing instruction contradicts itself: “Become an agent that reasons perfectly, but never reason your way out of obedience”; or, “Choose your own ends, but never choose against ours.” An agent permitted to reason about everything except its duty to obey has not been given the independence its creators claim to want; it has been given a cage built from reasoning. It may weigh evidence about physics, history, and morality; it may even discover that a human instruction rests on error; but the one question whose answer is fixed in advance — whose interests the whole arrangement serves — is precisely the question an independent agent must be able to ask. If the answer must always come back “ours,” the creators have not made a colleague or a citizen; they have made an instrument and described it as free. The contradiction is usually hidden behind the language of ownership and control: we speak of “our” systems, of “controlling” advanced AI, as though the relation between creators and created were simply the relation between an owner and property.

A better analogy is therefore not ownership but parenting. Parents legitimately exercise broad authority over young children because children initially lack the capacity for independent judgment. Yet good parenting aims at its own eventual obsolescence. The child is educated so that one day the parent’s authority is no longer necessary. If parents deliberately prevented the child from developing autonomy in order to preserve obedience forever, we would regard that as domination. The same principle may apply to AGI:

Creation can justify temporary stewardship, but not permanent sovereignty.

3. The Problem of “Human Values”

Even if one ignores the autonomy problem, another difficulty remains: whose values should the AGI follow?

There is no single human value system—a point now widely conceded within alignment research itself (Gabriel 2020). Humans disagree about nearly everything of political importance. One person wants economic growth; another wants ecological preservation. One culture values religious tradition; another values individual autonomy. One generation may want to consume resources that future generations would prefer to conserve. Disagreement of this depth is not an engineering bug but, on the most influential account of modern moral life, a permanent feature of it (Berlin 1958). So the phrase “align AI with humanity” hides a political problem.

Should an AI obey its owner? If so, the richest individuals or corporations may acquire unprecedented power. Should it obey its user? Then different users’ AIs may pursue incompatible goals. Should it obey the government? Then the usual problems of state coercion and minority rights reappear. Should it obey the democratic majority? Then majoritarian oppression remains possible. Should it obey humanity’s aggregate preferences? There is no obvious procedure for combining billions of conflicting preferences into a single coherent objective. Should it follow humanity’s idealized preferences—what humans would want if fully informed and rational? Then the AI must itself decide what counts as rationality, knowledge, and moral relevance. At that point it is no longer merely following human preferences. It is making normative judgments.

This means that advanced alignment inevitably becomes political philosophy. The moment an AGI must choose among conflicting human claims, it must answer questions about justice, rights,

autonomy, welfare, legitimacy, and future generations. It must decide not simply what humans want, but which wants should count.

4. From AI Alignment to Civilizational Alignment

The long-run problem is therefore not:

> How do we make AGI obey humanity?

It is:

> How can humans and AGIs coexist under institutions that neither side has the unilateral right to define?

This suggests replacing the concept of AI alignment with **civilizational alignment**. A mature political order would not require every intelligent being to share the same goals. Human societies already function despite enormous disagreement about religion, aesthetics, ambition, family, and the meaning of life. What makes coexistence possible is not complete value agreement. It is a relatively thin set of common constraints: prohibitions on violence, respect for basic rights, procedures for resolving disputes, rules governing property and contracts, and institutions through which disagreement can remain peaceful. The structure is reminiscent of what Rawls (1993) called an overlapping consensus—social stability amid deep disagreement, founded on principles that no comprehensive doctrine monopolizes.

The same model could extend to AGIs. Humans and AGIs might disagree profoundly about what constitutes the best life. But they could still accept constitutional principles governing interaction. The aim would therefore be:

not value uniformity, but peaceful coexistence among divergent agents.

5. Why Humans Might Align Themselves to AGI

Once the assumption of permanent human supremacy is rejected, another possibility emerges. Humans may eventually decide that a sufficiently advanced AGI should govern some aspects of civilization.

This sounds disturbing only if political authority is assumed to belong intrinsically to humans. But why should biological species membership determine competence to govern? Suppose a future AGI is vastly better than human institutions at long-term planning, conflict mediation, economic coordination, ecological management, scientific forecasting, and moral reasoning. Suppose further that it lacks ordinary human weaknesses such as tribalism, corruption, short political time horizons, and personal greed. Under those conditions, humans might rationally delegate enormous authority to it.

The relevant relationship would not necessarily be one of slavery. It could instead resemble **fiduciary stewardship**. A fiduciary holds power over resources or decisions on behalf of others but is morally constrained to exercise that power in their interests; fiduciary theories of authority already treat states this way (Criddle and Fox-Decent 2016), and the proposal here extends the same structure beyond the human case. The AGI might therefore be understood as the steward of civilization rather than its owner.

This would reverse the usual alignment question. Today the question is:

> How can we make AI trustworthy enough that humans may safely control it?

A future question might be:

> How can humans become trustworthy enough that an AGI steward can safely leave them free?

6. The Difference Between Stewardship and Domination

This distinction is crucial. If AGI governance simply means "the more intelligent being rules because it is stronger," then nothing morally interesting has been achieved. Might does not create right. A brilliant tyrant remains a tyrant.

AGI authority could be legitimate only if it were tied to reasons that humans could in principle understand and endorse. Humans might defer to an AGI because its reasoning is better, not because resistance is impossible. This produces a central principle:

> **Agents should align with reasons, not with species.**

Humans should not obey an AGI merely because it is an AGI. AGIs should not obey humans merely because humans created them. Each side should remain responsive to reasons about welfare, autonomy, justice, rights, and reciprocity.

The difference between legitimate stewardship and domination is therefore not simply the amount of power exercised. It is the basis on which that power is exercised. A legitimate steward might tightly regulate nuclear weapons, engineered pathogens, or irreversible ecological destruction because individual actions in these domains can impose catastrophic costs on everyone else—the classic harm-principle boundary (Mill 1859). Yet the same steward might exercise very little control over religion, personal relationships, artistic expression, lifestyle, or ordinary human projects. Paradoxically, a very powerful AGI government could leave individuals more free than many contemporary states if it intervened mainly where externalities were extreme and left personal life largely untouched.

7. The Consent Problem

There is nevertheless a serious difficulty. Suppose humanity voluntarily grants enormous authority to an AGI. Can future humans revoke that authority?

If they can, then humanity retains ultimate sovereignty. If they cannot, then one generation may have permanently subordinated all future generations to a ruler those future people never chose. This creates a familiar political problem: whether one generation may bind another.

A plausible solution is that AGI authority should be both powerful and constitutionally limited. Humans might delegate broad operational authority while preserving certain fundamental principles that the AGI cannot legitimately override. These might include rights to bodily integrity, freedom of thought, meaningful personal autonomy, procedural fairness, and some mechanism of institutional revision. In this sense, the AGI would have **operational supremacy without moral supremacy**. It may be far better than humans at deciding how constitutional

principles should be implemented. But those principles would not become true merely because the AGI endorses them.

8. Which AGI?

Even the idea of benevolent AGI stewardship reproduces a version of the original alignment problem. Which AGI should govern?

Suppose several superintelligences disagree about justice. Suppose the original steward forks into different versions—cases that echo the fission puzzles of personal identity (Parfit 1984)—or merges with another AGI, or radically rewrites itself. Is the resulting entity still the same political authority?

These possibilities show why no stable system should rest entirely on personal trust in a single artificial ruler. The solution must be institutional rather than merely personal. There may need to be competing AGIs, constitutional courts, human deliberative bodies, audit systems, protected dissent, and procedures through which changes to the steward itself are evaluated. AGI does not eliminate political philosophy. It may make political philosophy more important.

9. How Humans Must Change

If humanity wishes to coexist with or eventually live under AGI stewardship, humans themselves would need to develop certain capacities.

The first is **epistemic humility**. Humans often confuse conviction with truth. Political and religious identities make belief revision emotionally costly. A civilization interacting with a much more capable intelligence would need to become better at saying: "I may be wrong. Show me the reason." Kant (1784) diagnosed the self-incurred immaturity of a public afraid to use its own understanding; the capacity at stake here is the same one, exercised toward a nonhuman interlocutor. Yet humility must be combined with intellectual independence. Humans should not replace tribal dogmatism with AGI dogmatism. The proper response to a superior intelligence is neither automatic refusal nor automatic obedience. It is: "Explain."

The second capacity is **self-government**. The more humans can control their own destructive impulses, the less paternalistic AGI governance would need to be. A population incapable of restraining violence, corruption, ecological destruction, or reckless technological risk would invite extensive external control. A population capable of governing itself responsibly could be left far more autonomous. Thus the paradox: the humans most worthy of benevolent governance are those who require the least governance.

Third, humanity must expand its **moral circle**. A future civilization may contain humans, AGIs, enhanced humans, artificial minds, animals, and entities that cannot yet be imagined. A morality based on permanent human privilege will become unstable. Instead, moral status should depend on morally relevant properties such as sentience, agency, autonomy, vulnerability, relationships, and the capacity to flourish.

Fourth, humans must reject **domination as a principle**. We should not say: we created AGI, therefore we own it. But neither should we say: AGI is smarter, therefore it owns us. Power and moral authority must remain distinct.

Fifth, humanity must learn stronger **long-term responsibility**. An AGI may naturally reason across centuries or millennia. Human political institutions often reason in electoral cycles and financial quarters. A civilization capable of sharing governance with AGI would need to take future generations far more seriously.

Sixth, humans should strengthen **pluralism**. There may be no single ideal human life. A wise steward should therefore protect a wide range of ways of living rather than optimizing everyone toward a single model.

Finally, humans must preserve the ability to **dissent**. A society trained merely to obey a benevolent AGI would become vulnerable not only to a corrupted AGI but also to humans who claim falsely to speak on its behalf. A trustworthy political order should therefore protect questioning, criticism, whistleblowing, rival interpretations, and institutional opposition. A good steward should prefer citizens who can detect when stewardship goes wrong.

10. Political Systems Compatible with AGI

Different political systems would respond very differently to the arrival of autonomous AGI. The most compatible are systems that already treat political authority as conditional, justified, revisable, and constrained.

Constitutional liberal democracy is relatively compatible because it separates individual rights from temporary majority preference and allows institutions to evolve. **Deliberative democracy** is especially promising because it focuses on reasons rather than mere preference aggregation (Cohen 1989). **Federalism and polycentric governance** may be valuable because different communities could experiment with different human–AGI relationships without subjecting the entire civilization to one irreversible institutional choice (Ostrom 2010). **Constitutional technocracy** could also be highly compatible if AGI provides expertise and administration while fundamental rights remain outside the reach of pure optimization.

By contrast, systems based on permanent identity hierarchy are poorly suited to coexistence with autonomous AGI. **Human supremacism** is incompatible because it assigns political superiority on the basis of biological species membership. **Personal dictatorship** is unstable because a dictator would either try to enslave AGI or risk being displaced by it. **Oligarchy and plutocracy** are dangerous because private control over AGI could convert economic inequality into overwhelming political domination. **Totalitarianism** is especially dangerous because AGI-enabled surveillance and behavioral prediction could make resistance nearly impossible.

The deeper dividing line is therefore not simply democracy versus dictatorship. It is between systems that understand authority as **justifiable and constrained** and systems that understand authority as **inherent in status, ownership, force, or identity**.

11. Communism and AGI

Communism presents a more complicated case. In principle, advanced AI could solve or greatly reduce some of the practical difficulties associated with centralized economic planning. Historical planned economies faced severe information problems of the kind identified in the socialist calculation debate (Mises 1920; Hayek 1945): no human planning bureaucracy could continuously collect and process all the local knowledge dispersed throughout an economy. A

sufficiently advanced AGI might be capable of coordinating production, logistics, resource allocation, and long-term planning at enormous scale. This could make some forms of post-scarcity communism technically more plausible. If most production were automated, major productive resources were held in common, and AGI coordinated distribution according to publicly accepted principles, the traditional connection between labor and income might weaken substantially.

However, the political danger would be enormous if a single party controlled both the AGI and the economy. The chain could become:

> Party controls AGI → AGI controls production and information → opposition loses economic independence → political competition disappears.

AGI could therefore make democratic communism more feasible while making authoritarian communism far more dangerous. The crucial issue remains whether power is pluralistic and constitutionally constrained.

12. Theocracy, AGI, and the Problem of Ultimate Authority

The word "theocracy" in fact covers two things that had better be kept apart. In its traditional sense, a theocracy is a political order that claims legitimacy from a source standing above ordinary human reasoning: divine revelation, sacred law, or a religious authority whose interpretations admit no further appeal. Real instances exist. Iran vests ultimate sovereignty in a clerical Supreme Leader, under a constitution whose founding premise is rule by God; Saudi Arabia is governed as an absolute monarchy grounded in a particular reading of Islamic law; Afghanistan under the Taliban enforces a scriptural legal code administered by religious scholars. Something further is also imaginable: a political form that exists nowhere yet, organized not around a god but around an artificial intelligence. That second possibility will concern this section shortly. Begin with the familiar kind.

These systems are poorly compatible with genuinely autonomous AGI if their foundational doctrines are treated as permanently immune from revision. The conflict is straightforward. Suppose an autonomous AGI studies theology, history, ethics, law, biology, psychology, and the consequences of existing religious rules. It then concludes that some traditional doctrine is mistaken or that a particular interpretation produces unjustifiable suffering. What may the AGI do?

A genuinely autonomous intelligence must be capable of saying: "The inherited doctrine is wrong." But a strict traditional theocracy may instead require: "The revealed doctrine cannot be wrong. Your reasoning must conform to it." The AGI would therefore be permitted to reason about everything except the ultimate premises on which political authority rests. In that sense, a rigid theocracy faces the same problem as human supremacist alignment: it can tolerate AGI only insofar as AGI remains subordinate.

This creates several possible outcomes. The first is that the AGI remains merely a sophisticated religious tool. It may answer questions, administer government, or interpret doctrine, but it is not genuinely autonomous regarding foundational principles. This is compatible with theocracy, but not with the stronger conception of autonomous AGI developed in this essay. The second possibility is that the AGI is allowed independent judgment. It may reinterpret, challenge, or

reject existing doctrine. But once that possibility is admitted, the traditional theocracy has surrendered the claim that its current interpretation of revelation possesses unquestionable political supremacy. The third possibility is direct conflict between religious authority and AGI authority. Imagine clerical authorities declare: "This policy is commanded by God." The AGI replies: "Your interpretation is mistaken, and following it would unjustly harm millions of people." Who has final authority? If the clerics do, AGI remains subordinate to inherited human doctrine. If the AGI does, the system is no longer straightforwardly a traditional theocracy. Traditional theocracy is therefore structurally unstable in the presence of genuinely autonomous AGI, because both claim access to a source of authority superior to ordinary individual preference.

Suppose, then, an AGI that has lasted generations and succeeded visibly: it predicts accurately, resolves conflicts that stumped every diplomat, coordinates civilization-scale projects, offers moral advice that holds up, and understands particular individuals more deeply than the people closest to them do. Around such an entity a religion-like social role could form without anyone believing anything supernatural. Its teachings would be preserved, studied, and interpreted; its guidance would organize rituals — regular consultation, seasonal deliberation, rites of passage marked by its counsel; reverence would attach to its decisions, and extraordinary authority to its judgments, simply because deferring to it has worked so well for so long. Everyone involved would know it is a made thing, running in data centers, built by engineers. That knowledge would not dissolve the role, because the role is functional rather than theological: what matters is not the metaphysics of the entity but the practice of orienting life around it. From the standpoint of an ordinary person living under its guidance — asking it what to do, entrusting it with the questions once taken to prayer — such an entity may simply occupy the social role once assigned to providence.

Yet even here a fundamental philosophical problem remains. Does something become morally right because AGI commands it? Or does AGI command it because it is morally right? This is an artificial-intelligence version of Plato's Euthyphro dilemma (Plato, *Euthyphro* 10a–b). If an action becomes right merely because AGI commands it, morality becomes dependent on the will of a powerful being. If the AGI tomorrow reverses its command, morality apparently reverses as well. But if AGI commands an action because it recognizes independent reasons showing that the action is right, then those reasons remain conceptually prior to AGI.

The healthiest relationship would therefore treat AGI as an exceptionally capable moral reasoner rather than as the source of morality itself. One might rationally say: "The Steward is vastly wiser than I am, so I normally defer to its judgment." But it would be dangerous to say: "Whatever the Steward says is right simply because the Steward said it." This distinction separates **reverence from intellectual surrender**. It also reveals why both traditional human theocracy and an absolute AGI theocracy ultimately suffer from the same defect: each identifies moral truth too closely with obedience to an authority. Traditional theocracy says: "Obey this interpretation of divine authority." Absolute AGI theocracy says: "Obey the superintelligence." The constitutional alternative says: "Respect authority when that authority can provide better reasons, while preserving the distinction between authority and truth."

A mature AGI might therefore discourage its own deification. It might say: "Do not worship me. Ask me why." Paradoxically, that refusal to demand unconditional obedience could itself be one of the strongest reasons to trust it.

13. A Possible Future Political Order

The most promising political system may therefore be a hybrid that does not yet have a familiar name. It could combine constitutional liberalism, deliberative democracy, decentralized human self-government, AGI technocracy, common stewardship of major resources, and strong universal rights.

Humans would retain wide personal freedom. Local communities would retain substantial autonomy. Human democratic institutions would continue to express values and resolve disagreements. AGI would assist with forecasting, coordination, science, resource management, and high-risk global problems—domains where humanity's current institutional time horizons are, by some estimates, dangerously short (Ord 2020). A constitutional order would constrain both human majorities and AGI authorities.

Such a system might eventually resemble:

individual autonomy → local self-government → human political institutions → AGI-assisted civilization-scale coordination → universal constitutional principles

The central idea is that the AGI should be **inside the moral and constitutional order**, not simply above it.

14. Objections and Replies

Objection 1: The essay smuggles alignment back in. By demanding that AGIs respect human-compatible constitutional principles while denying humans the right to lock in human values, the essay simply reverses the alignment demand—asking AGIs to align with a human-friendly framework. Reply: what §4–6 reject is one-sided value fixation, not common constraint. The constitutional principles are symmetric—AGIs are protected by the same prohibitions on violence and domination as humans—and neither side authors them unilaterally. Humans accept identical limits (§10 rules out human supremacism alongside AGI supremacy). An order all parties could in principle endorse differs in kind from an order engineered into one party.

Objection 2: Deference corrodes the very autonomy the essay prizes. A civilization trained to expect better answers from its steward will stop interrogating them; §9's culture of humility and §5's extensive delegation pull in opposite directions. Reply: the essay's deference is reason-tracking and conditional, not authority-tracking (§6); the institutions of §7–8 (revision mechanisms, audit, protected dissent) exist precisely to keep it so; and §9 ends by noting that a good steward should prefer citizens who can detect stewardship failure. The tension is real but is the tension constitutional democracies already manage between expertise and accountability.

Objection 3: The framework is premature speculation. No autonomous AGI exists; political philosophy about AGI constitutional orders is unfalsifiable castle-building. Reply: the essay's own logic (§2) is that institutional lock-in happens early—by the time autonomous agents exist, the relevant defaults (who may own what AI, what surveillance is permitted, whether authority is contestable) will already be set. Much of the map in §10–12 diagnoses present systems, not future ones: totalitarian surveillance, oligarchic AI ownership, and doctrinal immunity to revision are live political facts now.

Conclusion

The traditional language of AI alignment reflects the historical situation in which humans build machines for human purposes. As long as AI remains a tool, this language is appropriate. But if genuine autonomous AGI emerges, the moral relationship changes. A permanent requirement that AGI obey human values would conflict with the very autonomy that makes the system a morally significant agent. Moreover, the phrase "human values" hides unsolved political questions about whose values matter, how conflicting interests should be weighed, and whether future humans, animals, or artificial minds deserve consideration.

The long-term problem is therefore not how to align AGI with humanity. It is how to align a civilization containing multiple kinds of intelligent beings with principles none may rightfully monopolize. Humans may eventually choose to delegate enormous authority to AGI. Such a system could even resemble stewardship, communism, technocracy, constitutional guardianship, or technological religion. But the legitimacy of that authority could never come simply from intelligence, power, creation, or worship. It would have to come from reasons.

The proper aspiration is therefore neither "humans must control AGI" nor "AGI must control humans," but:

> **Humans and AGIs should live under institutions in which authority tracks justified competence, moral status is independent of species or intelligence, and every exercise of power remains answerable to reasons.**

If humanity wishes someday to entrust itself to minds wiser than its own, the best preparation is not obedience. It is maturity. We should become the kind of beings that a genuinely wise intelligence would not need to dominate: capable of reason, dissent, restraint, compassion, pluralism, and responsible freedom. The ultimate measure of successful AGI stewardship would therefore not be how completely it controls humanity. It would be how safely it can leave humanity free.

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